To

step into a room full of Atul Dodiya's paintings is to enter a conversation that spans centuries, cultures and continents. It is a world where lines from a 17th-century Spanish poem might whisper to a more contemporary day in Lahore or a sparrow from Thane may find itself in the streets of Manhattan.

After a six-year hiatus from the capital, the prominent Mumbai-based artist has returned to Delhi with a solo exhibition that is as much about the act of looking as it is about the subjects being looked at. The title of the exhibition, *The Gatecrasher*, is borrowed from one of the 12 large-scale oil paintings on display at Vadehra Art Gallery, and the works offer a glimpse into 'laboratories' of memory and archives of a life lived through the lens of art.

There are paintings within paintings; viewers watching viewers who are, in turn, viewing the art. Complicated as that may sound, everything falls into place when you stand looking at them. "I love looking at art, and I also feel that, when a viewer is perceiving whatever the artist is trying to say, there is a kind of give and take that takes place between them," says Dodiya. Memory, he believes, plays a big role. "You see something and you are reminded of something else. Which leads me to, 'What if I combine them?' If I bring that aspect of memory into the present, it no longer remains in the past," he says.

In a painting titled 'The Third Eye', for instance, there is a woman looking at a painting with her back towards the viewer. "The way her hair is piled up, it reminded me of Shiva, so I thought of painting Shiva's face on her hair," says Dodiya. However, it does not end there. "There needs to be an element of surprise in any painting. When I thought of painting Shiva, for instance, I did not know which Shiva to paint—from an earlier oleograph or a more recent one, or go for a Rajput miniature. I should be baffled by my own work. If I am not baffled, then it will be difficult for me to surprise my viewer," he adds.

An element of surprise for the viewer, particularly in this exhibition, is the presence of other artists or their works on the canvas. In 'The Gatecrasher', his



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▶ EXHIBITION

Silence Bears Weight

TYEB MEHTA'S CENTENARY EXHIBITION REFRAMES HIS ART BEYOND VIOLENCE, TOWARD HEALING, STRUCTURE AND IMAGINATION

Famously (or infamously), Tyeb Mehta (1925-2009) is the Indian modernist held responsible for introducing Indian art to the 'million-dollar club'. In 2005, his artwork 'Mahishasura' fetched a whopping $1.6 million at a Christie's auction in New York, something his daughter Himani Mehta Dehlvi said in a recent interview he would "have a hearty laugh about".

Mehta was among the pioneers in the Progressive Artists' Group, founded in 1947, whose visceral memories of loss and violence during the Partition informed his oeuvre. One can almost touch the helplessness of a free fall, tethered to nothing but devastation in Mehta's works that continue to capture the world's imagination.

As recently as 2025, Mehta's 1956 oil on canvas, titled 'Trussed Bull', became the second-most expensive work of Indian art to sell at an auction, fetching $7.2 million. His centenary year continues to be celebrated with the exhibition *Tyeb Mehta: Bearing Weight*

